

INTRODUCTION TO SYNTAX I

Session 5: Clause structure II

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July 31st 2026

OVA 2026

TODAY'S PLAN

- Clause types
- Complementizers
- One full derivation

■ We landed on complementizers heading our clausal structure.

- ⊙ Complementizers precede the subject of the finite clause.
- ⊙ They form a constituent with the TP $\Rightarrow$ they are part of the embedded clause:

- (1) a. I wonder **whether** she will sleep.
b. **Whether** she will sleep, I wonder.
c. *She will sleep, I wonder **whether**.

- ⊙ But where is the complementizer located in our syntactic structure?

■ What is the function of the complementizer?

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(2) a. I think [(that) David left].

b. *Hungarian*

Az-t hisz-em, [(hogy) Dávid el-men-t].

DEM-ACC believe-1SG COMP David PV-go-PST.3SG

'I think (that) David left.'

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'I think (that) David left.'

- ⊙ *David left* seems to be a complete TP, regardless of *that*.
 - ⊙ The complementizer *that* is optional here but seems to **act as a bridge** between the main and the embedded clause.
- ⇒ The complementizer **does not belong to the TP**.

LOCATING THE COMPLEMENTIZER

(3) a. I [_{VP} **know** [_{?P} $\left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{that} \\ \text{whether} \\ \text{if} \end{array} \right\}$ David left]]

LOCATING THE COMPLEMENTIZER

- (3) a. I [_{VP} **know** [_{?P} {
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Verbs select complements, sometimes clausal ones.

- ⊙ The **complementizer** is indicative of the **clause type** (interrogative or declarative)
- ⇒ It depends on the complementizer whether the embedded clause can Merge with the main clause verb ⇒ the complementizer projects its features!

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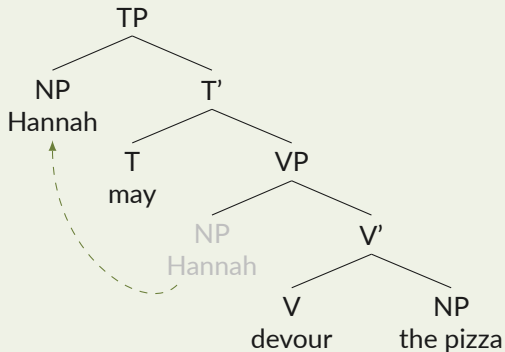
- (4) a. You may know [(that) she fell asleep]. clause = complement of V $\Rightarrow$ object of *know*
b. [That she fell asleep] may surprise you. clause = specifier of T $\Rightarrow$ subject of *surprise*
- ⊙ Notice that when the clause is the subject, the complementizer becomes obligatory ((4b) is bad if we omit *that*)!

THE TREE IS GROWING

I Our structure so far

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Our structure so far

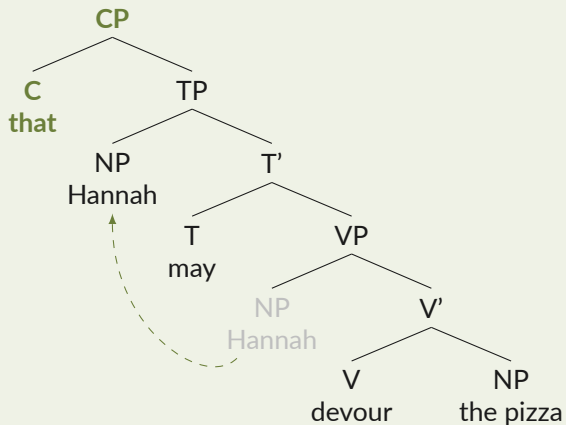


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THE TREE IS GROWING

■ All signs point to the complementizer being a head.

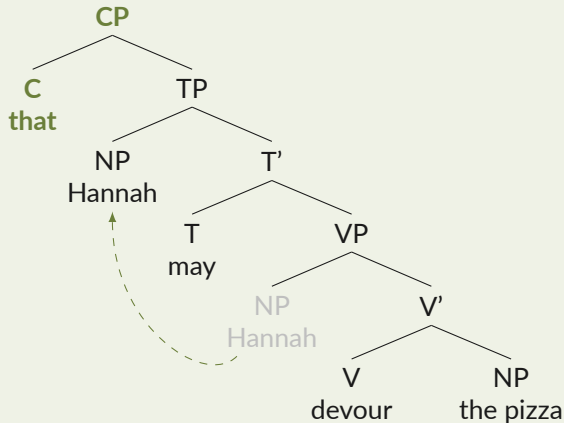
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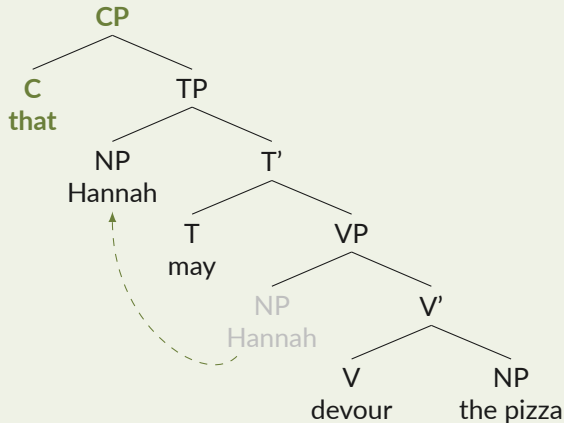


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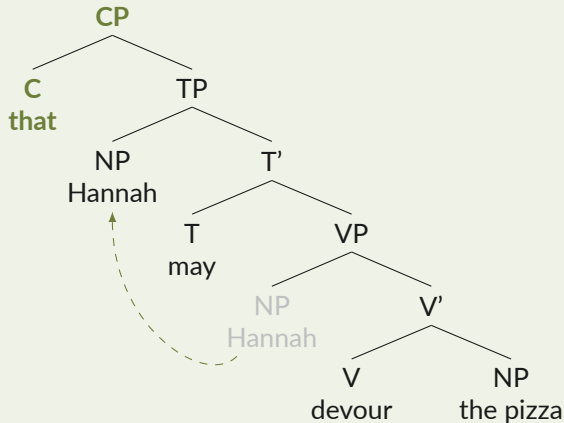


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- ◉ We label this **head C**(omplementizer).
- ◉ Clauses are of category [C], verbs that select clauses have the c-selectional feature [uC].

(Apologies for absolutely everything being called a (distinct!) c-something, the field could have done better.)

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- a. Finn hat geschlafen.
Finn have.3SG slept
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Sarah think-3SG Finn have.3SG slept
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Sarah think-3SG Finn have.3SG slept
'Sarah thinks Finn slept.'
- c. Sarah denk-t, **dass** Finn **geschlafen hat**.
Sarah think-3SG COMP Finn slept have.3SG
'Sarah thinks that Finn slept.'

■ Complementizers are obligatory in Scottish Gaelic and French:

(8) *Scottish Gaelic*

- a. Thuairt mi **gu** bheil i tinn.
say-PST I COMP was she ill
'I said that she was ill.'
- b. *Thuairt mi bheil i tinn.
say-PST I was she ill

(9) *French*

- a. J'ai dit **qu'** elle était malade
I-have said COMP she was ill
'I said that she was ill.'
- b. *J'ai dit elle était malade
I-have said she was ill

ALMOST QUESTIONS

- (10) a. I know that **Hannah** might devour the pizza.
b. I know (*that) **who** might devour the pizza.
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- English has SVO word order, with a subject in SpecTP and the object as the complement of the verb.
- But why does the **object precede the embedded subject** in (10d)?
- And where did the **complementizer** go in (10b) and (10d)?

■ *Who and which pizza differ from Hannah and the pizza.*

- ⊙ They are still the arguments of the predicate *devour* in (10), omitting them is bad:

- (11) a. *I know might devour the pizza.
b. *I know Hannah will devour.

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■ We have previously argued based on complementary distribution.

- ◉ We declared modals, emphatic *do* and infinitival *to* T heads because they could not co-occur (recall session 4).
- ◉ Given that *who* and *which pizza* seem to be in complementary distribution with the C head *that*, should we assume that they are C heads, too?

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 - ⊙ So how can *who* and *which pizza* be locally selected by *devour* and simultaneously be in a position that interacts with the C head?
- $\Rightarrow$ **In other words, how can something behave like it's in two positions at once?**

■ Recall the EPP feature on the T head.

- ◉ We saw that English finite clauses require a subject (structurally higher than auxiliaries).
- ⇒ To account for this, we assumed that the T head has a **requirement to fill its specifier**.
- ◉ We modeled this requirement by postulating the EPP-feature, either attracting the noun/clause from SpecVP or requiring an expletive if the verb selects no arguments.

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REQUIREMENTS OF C

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- ⊙ C, being a functional head like T, also wants its specifier to be filled.
- ⊙ C's purpose is marking clause type: it is sensitive to, among others, *wh-phrases*.¹

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■ The feature on C can be satisfied via Merge.

- ⊙ In embedded declaratives, a complementizer is Merged in the head position (*that*).
- ⊙ In embedded interrogatives, an interrogative complementizer is Merged in the head position (*whether/if*).

FORMALIZING C'S REQUIREMENTS

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- In embedded declaratives, a complementizer is Merged in the head position (*that*).
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■ The feature on C can also be satisfied via movement.

- If there is a suitable phrase in the structure, C attracts it to its specifier.
- ⇒ C attracts constituents in its c-command domain that have a [+Q] feature (relevant for clause type, information structure, etc.)
- We have only looked at wh-phrases moving to SpecCP, but C attracts several types of phrases that carry relevant for clause type!

APPLYING EVERYTHING WE HAVE LEARNED SO FAR

■ Let's derive *I know which pizza Hannah may devour*.

APPLYING EVERYTHING WE HAVE LEARNED SO FAR

(12)

V	NP
devour	which pizza
[uN, uN]	

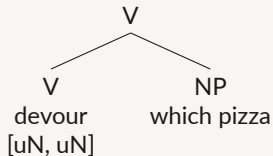
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(12)

V
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[uN, uN]

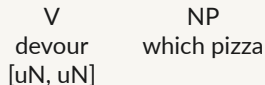
NP
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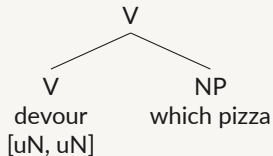


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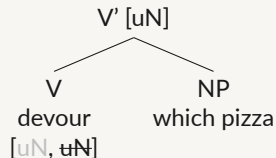
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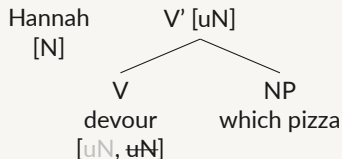
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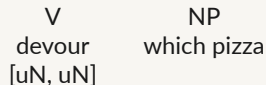


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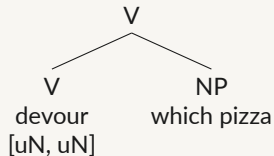


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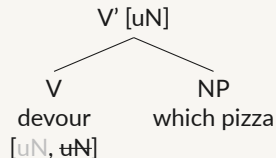
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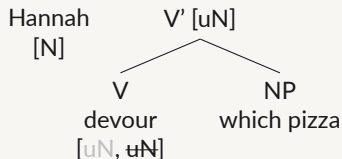
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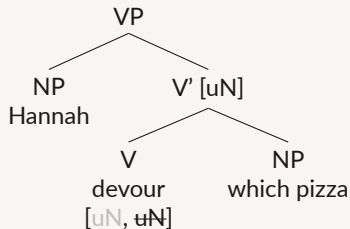
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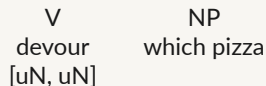


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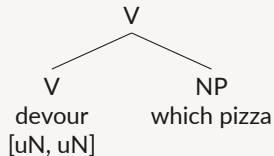


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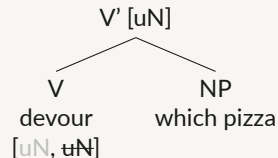
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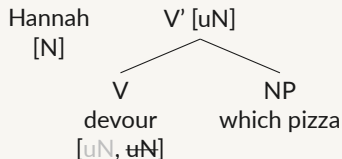
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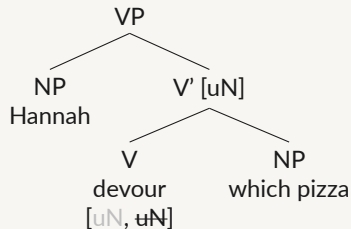
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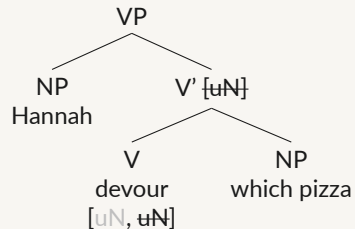
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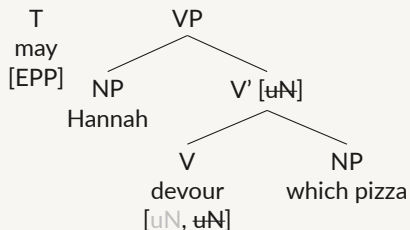


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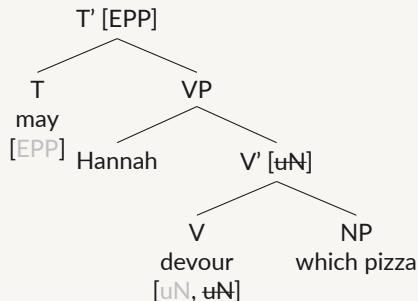


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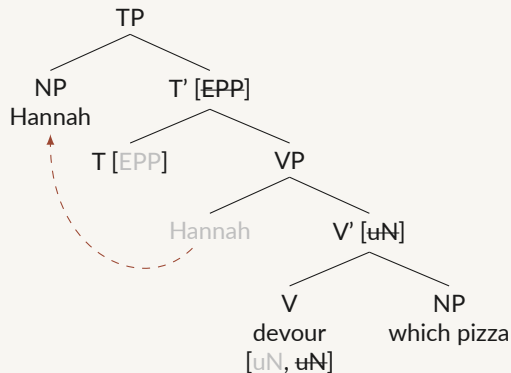


■ **Reminder: functional heads do not have an argument structure like lexical heads do.**

- ⊙ While elements within the lexical projection combine based on the respective predicates' argument structure, functional heads like T and C have more rigid requirements to build the clausal spine: T needs a VP, C needs a TP.

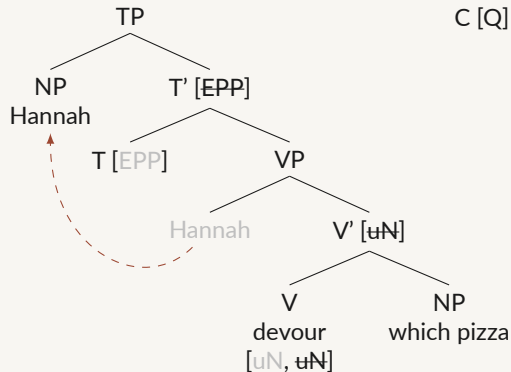
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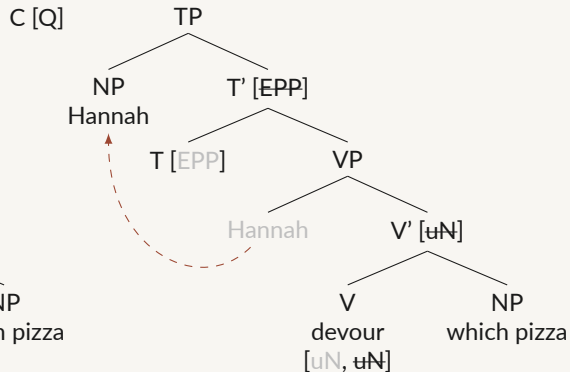


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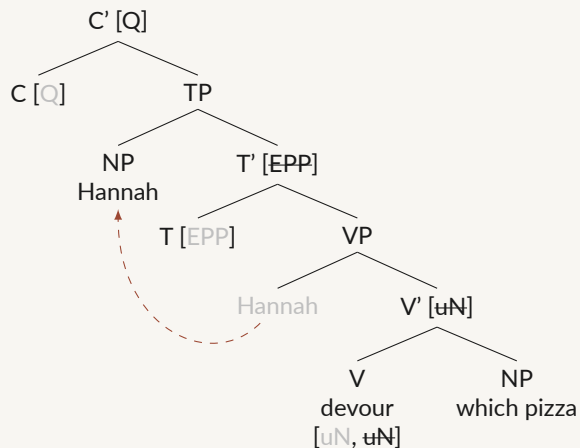
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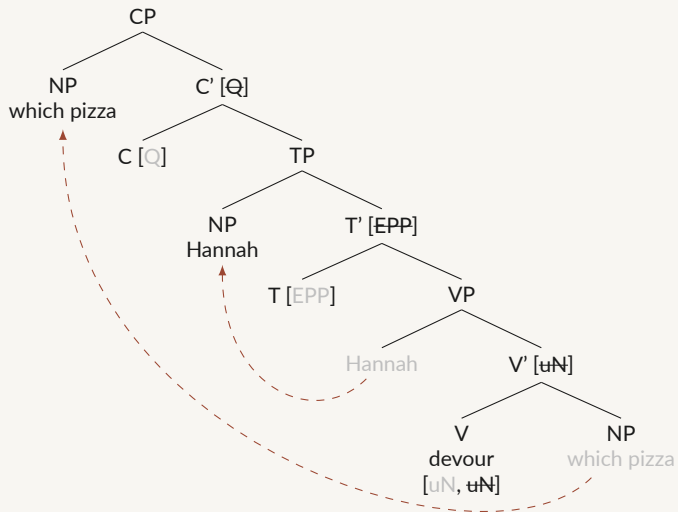
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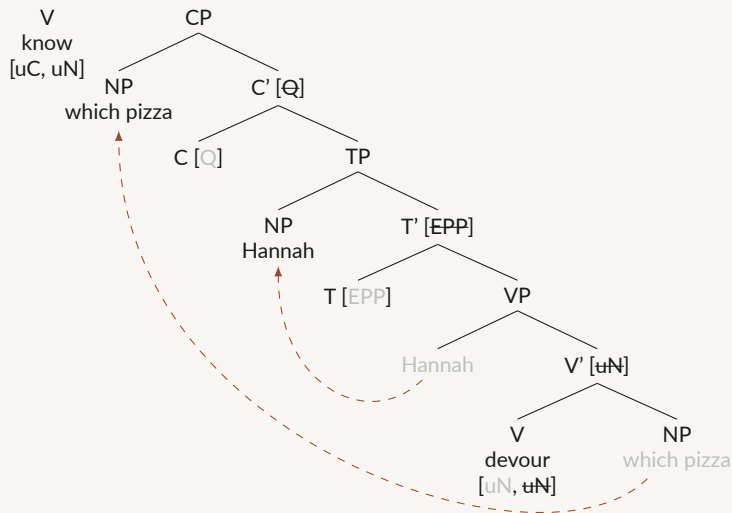
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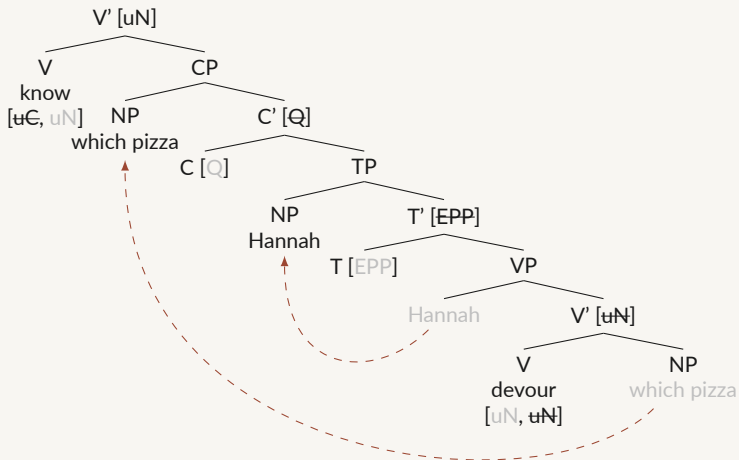
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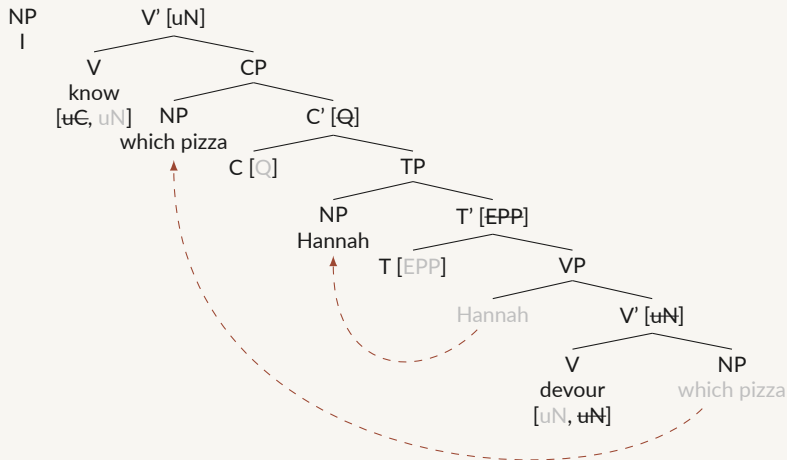
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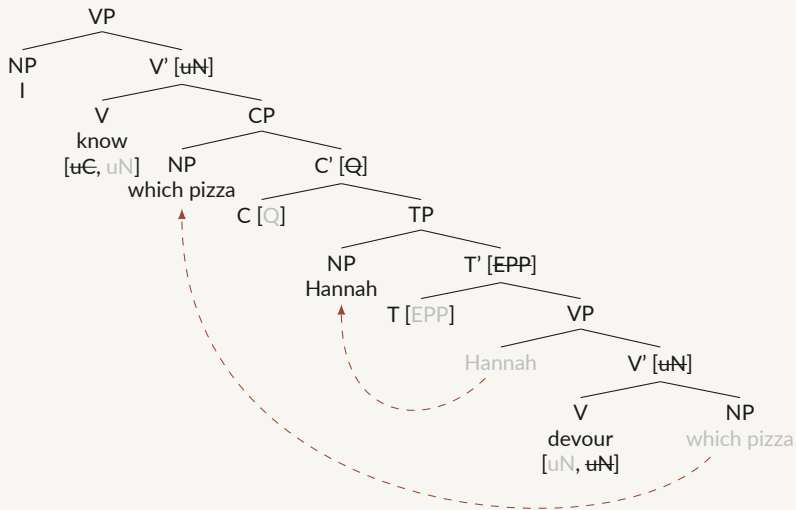
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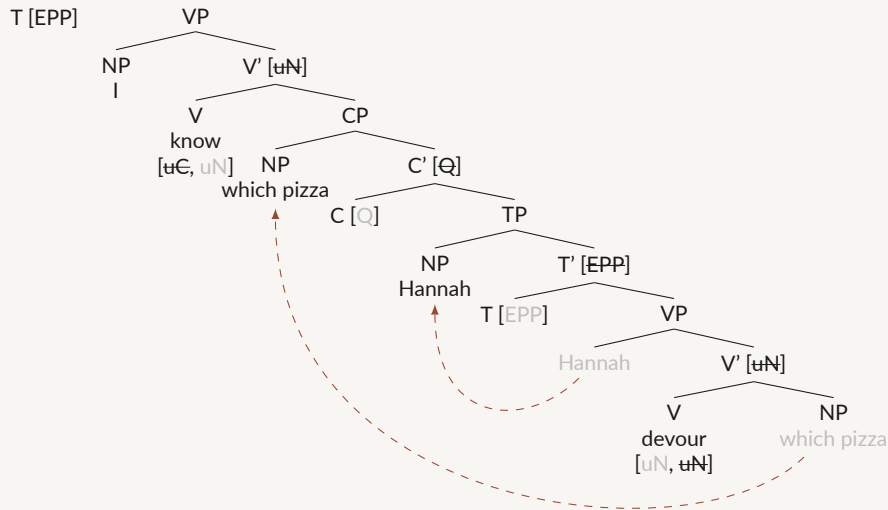
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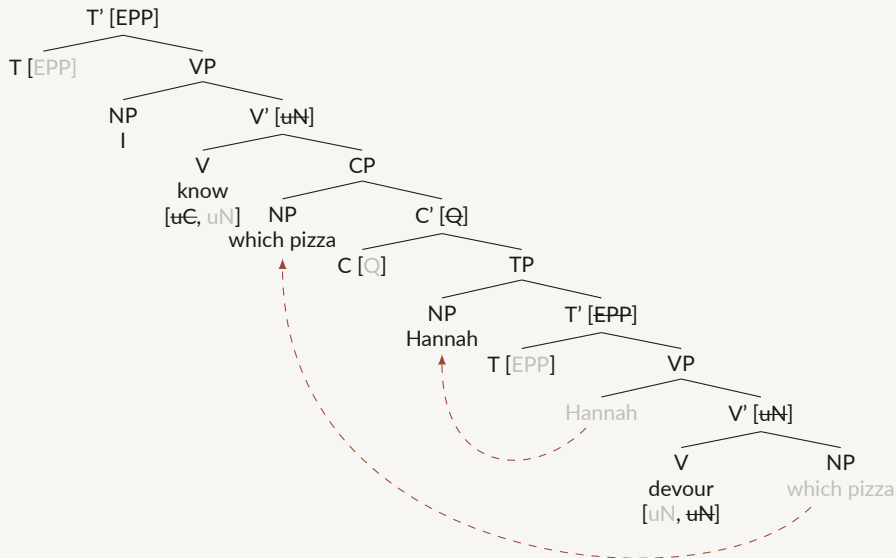
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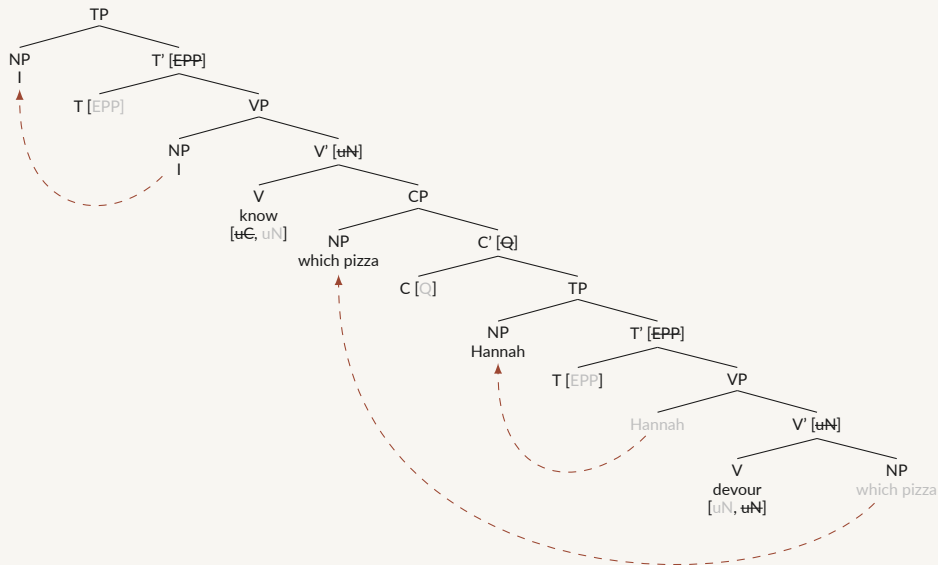
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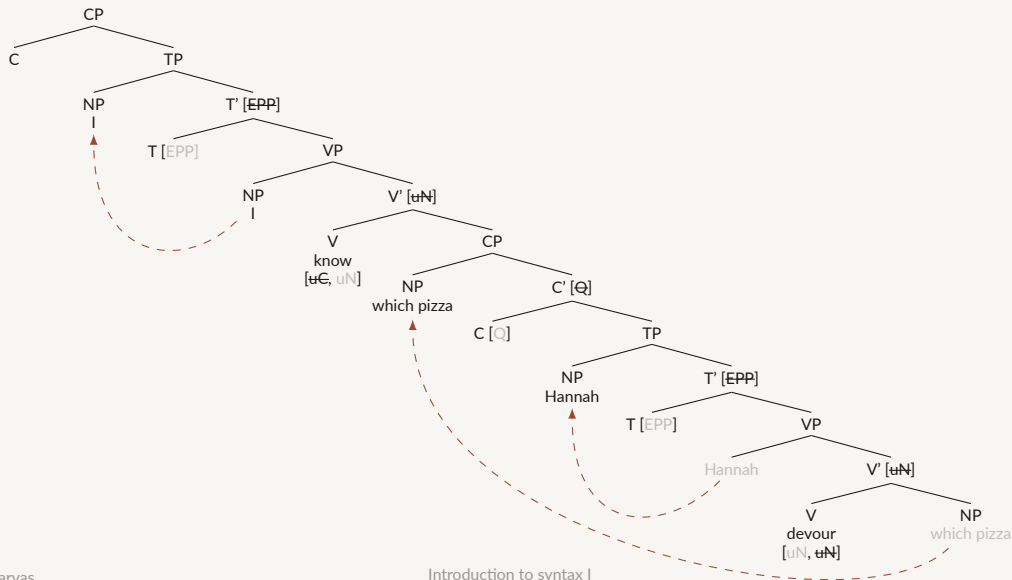
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UNDERLYING VS. SURFACE POSITIONS

I Recall the term 'base generation'

- ◉ We briefly mentioned in session 4 that the subject is **base generated** (i.e. Merged) in SpecVP but ends up **moving** to SpecTP in our model.
- ◉ We now saw wh-phrases that are base generated in the lexical projection (VP), too, and end up moving to SpecCP.
- ◉ When referring to a **constituent's origin**, i.e. the position where it was base generated/Merged, we often use the terms **base position** or **underlying position**.
- ◉ When referring to a constituent's final destination, i.e. the position to which it moves, we often use the terms **(final) landing site**, **derived position** or **surface position**.

UNDERLYING VS. SURFACE POSITIONS

■ Representing underlying vs. surface positions

- ⊙ Every constituent has a base position; the ones that move also have a landing site.
- ⊙ In earlier theories (Government & Binding, $\bar{x}$ -theory), sentences were modeled to have two levels: D-structure (for *deep*) and S-structure (for *surface*).

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Syntax keeps track of every step of the computational process.

- ◉ Recall structural ambiguities (session 1): silent syntactic structure reveals itself via the consequences it has for the interpretation (LF) and pronunciation (PF)!
- ◉ **Prediction:** if syntactic structures are built in a computational process, there should be evidence (on PF and/or LF) for each step.

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- ⇒ The **functional head** that attracts them to their surface position under non-local c-command (filling the specifier position of T/C).
- ⊙ The default rule for the languages you have seen so far is to take the final position into account for pronunciation (i.e. PF references only the final landing site).
- ⊙ Semantically, base positions matter a lot (LF often references base positions).

Thank you for attending!

Questions?